

The Water Of Life: Irish Whiskey [C1]

In Irlanda non si beve solo birra: il whiskey dell'isola di Smeraldo (quello con la 'e') ha una storia che risale addirittura al Medioevo. Scopriamo quali sono le caratteristiche principali dell'“acqua della vita”.



Whiskey is one of Ireland's primary exports, with an estimated value of over €1 billion per year. Since its creation in the 12th century, this amber-coloured liquor has been a prominent player in Irish life and culture, but recently, it has been experiencing a renaissance.

RISE AND DECLINE

Irish whiskey experienced its golden era between the 18th and 19th centuries, when it became one of the best-known distilled [spirits](#) in the world. Ireland was then part of the British Empire, and Irish whiskey was sold throughout its dominions, especially across the ocean to the young nation of the United States, which became one of its biggest markets. However, two events [dealt a major blow](#) to Irish whiskey sales globally: the rise of [blended](#) Scotch whisky in the late 19th century, which gained popularity due to its [affordability](#) and [smoother](#) taste; and Prohibition in the United States (1920-1933), which abruptly cut off a key export market. Irish whiskey then experienced a prolonged decline due to a combination of internal political instability, trade barriers with Britain and resistance to adopting new distillation technologies. As a result, the number of distilleries in Ireland [dropped](#) from over eighty in the 19th century to just four by 2010.

HUNDREDS OF MILLIONS OF LITRES

In 2010, the Irish whiskey industry began to recover, with a wave of both new and revived distilleries. Today, there are over fifty operational distilleries throughout the island, from the historic Kilbeggan Distillery, originally licensed in 1757, to the newest, Clonakilty Distillery, which officially opened in West Cork in March 2019. Together, they produce an estimated 135 million litres of whiskey annually, 90 per cent of which is exported to over 110 countries.

ORIGINS

To get a better [insight](#) into Irish whiskey's history and evolution to this day, Speak Up spoke to John Callely of Whiskey Island, a [family-run business](#) that promotes whiskey tourism, offering everything from corporate tours to [tastings](#). He spoke about the unclear origins of this popular drink, which some date back to the 12th century, when Irish monks are believed to have learned the art of distillation — brought into Europe by the Arabs — and began distilling cereals such as [barley](#).

John Callely (Irish accent): It was the Moors who had come to Europe and settled in Spain. Obviously, they were Muslims, so they were non-drinkers, but they were distilling. And the art of distilling is, you essentially have a beer in a chamber and you heat it up and you vaporize the beers. You're taking a [spirit](#) and you're leaving water and impurities behind. You start with a beer-like substance and you end up with a [spirit](#). Now, they weren't drinking it, they were using it as a

medicine, really. But then, when they were [pushed out](#) of Europe, it had [made its way into](#) the monasteries of Ireland. And monasteries were the first large-scale [breweries](#). There was [were] lots of beer made in these monasteries, and then they discovered this whole art of distillation; they could use it to distill beer and they've got a very strong potent [spirit](#).

THE WATER OF LIFE

The first known written reference to whiskey in Ireland appears in the Annals of Clonmacnoise (1405), a Gaelic historical chronicle translated into English in the 17th century, but the earliest written recipe is found in the Red Book of Ossory, a 14th-century manuscript held in County Kilkenny. The book is best known for containing Latin hymns and ecclesiastical texts, but it also includes instructions for distilling aqua vitae, Latin for 'water of life', a term translated into Irish as uisce beatha, leading eventually to the anglicised whiskey. **John Callely:** It was missionary monks that travelled around the world and they spread distillation around the world. All these things [that] start medicinally become recreational [to an extent](#). You had aqua vitae, which is what the first drink in its first form was called, and then as it made its way around Europe, it became eau de vie in France. In Ireland and Scotland, it became uisce beatha. Uisce beatha is the 'water of life'. And that's what we were drinking here in Ireland and in Scotland. It was a distilled [spirit](#) from [barley](#). In France, it was grapes. Mexico, they were making tequila, mezcal. In Russia and Poland, they were making vodka. And then in the [Low Countries](#), Holland and parts of northern France, they were making jenever, which would later become gin. So when we were invaded, when the English arrived, obviously our new English overlords would find it very difficult to get their tongue around a word like uisce beatha. But if you look at 'uisce' phonetically, U-I-S-C-E, and you try to pronounce it: uisce; whiskey. And that's where the word 'whiskey' in its modern form comes from.

IRISH VS. SCOTCH

Irish whiskey held global prominence for over a century, but its [reluctance](#) to embrace innovation would eventually prove [costly](#). As new distillation techniques [emerged](#), Irish producers [hesitated](#), while their Scottish counterparts [seized the opportunity](#). **John Callely:** It was really late 1700s and for all of the 1800s, Irish whiskey [ruled the world](#), really. We were the second biggest-selling drinks category after rum. So any country with a [navy](#) would have big [supplies](#) of rum for their [sailors](#). Irish whiskey, number two. We had eighty-eight licensed distilleries. We had many unlicensed illegal distilleries, but that's another story. And we were selling about twelve million cases every year around the world. A lot of those sales were USA, but there was a new technology available at the time that the Irish distillers ignored. And that was a big problem because this new

technology revolutionized the way whiskey was made. The inventor was Irish. He went to Scotland, he sold this technology to Johnnie Walker... the big ones, the big Scotch companies, and they started blending whiskey. And that gave the world a Scottish blend. And that changed everything. So Irish whiskey started to really decline and distillery after distillery closed. And by the 1960s, there was [were] only five [brands](#) left that were still just about [hanging in there](#). And they [merged](#), formed one company and started to rebuild Irish whiskey as a category again.

WHISKY OR WHISKEY?

You might have seen ‘whiskey’ [spelled](#) both with an ‘ey’ and just a ‘y’ — this variation [traces back to](#) a 19th-century rivalry during [trade wars](#), when Irish whiskey was considered to be of higher quality. However, a less expensive [blended](#) whisky from Scotland began [flooding](#) the market, sparking a fierce rivalry. In order to [set their product apart](#), some Irish distillers adopted the spelling ‘whiskey’ with an ‘e’ as a marketing strategy. Irish immigrants later brought this spelling to the United States, and today, the standard remains: Ireland and the United States use ‘whiskey’, while Scotland, Canada, and Japan use ‘whisky’. Beyond spelling, there’s also a technical difference in production: ‘whiskey’ is typically triple-distilled, resulting in a [smoother](#) taste, whereas ‘whisky’ is usually double-distilled, which gives it a [bolder](#), more robust flavour.

THE WHISKEY DRINKER

Paradoxically, [despite](#) its international prestige, whiskey has long struggled to establish itself in Ireland. For decades, domestic consumption remained modest, influenced by tradition and habit. However, the profile of the typical Irish whiskey drinker has changed. **John Callely:** The profile of the whiskey drinker has changed. The Irish market is a really good market again for Irish whiskey, but the [former](#), the old consumer of whiskey used to be predominantly male, older, and would be drinking a glass of Guinness on a bar [stool](#) in a pub with a little whiskey chaser. Maybe a [drop](#) of Jameson or Powers, and he’d be drinking the beer and the whiskey simultaneously. It really was just a very small fragment of our drinking population that were drinking whiskey. And it took a long time to get younger markets drinking whiskey again. And now you’ve got younger people, eighteen to thirty-five, who tend to be drinking less and spending a little bit more money on something that’s going to cost a little bit more, but last a little bit longer. So you see groups of friends now in bars in Dublin ordering a round of whiskey sours.

FLAVOUR COMPLEXITY

Contrary to popular belief, there is no single correct way to enjoy whiskey. Yet there is one approach that experts consistently [discourage](#) if one wants to savour

it in all its complexity. **John Calley:** I often have to say it at the beginning of a tastin; people will come over, they see whiskey and the first thing they want to do with it is to pick it up and [knock it back](#) like they're drinking sambuca or tequila, which again, you shouldn't do. Because all you're getting when you [knock it back in one](#), all you're getting is the alcohol and you're missing all of the flavour. The only way you'll see the flavour is if you take little [sips](#) and you're, "Wow, I really wasn't expecting that!" That's what you hear all the time. "God, I wasn't expecting it to taste like that! That's really good." And that's really probably another big reason why Irish people need a little bit of [warming up](#) because for so long they've been drinking it the wrong way.

THE RIGHT WAY

So what about adding water, ice, or mixing whiskey into cocktails? While purists may [raise an eyebrow](#), the reality is far more interesting. According to Calley, whiskey can be enjoyed in a variety of ways, without compromising its essence.

John Calley: Some purists will say, "Oh, you shouldn't put ice in whiskey because it'll mask some of the flavour. You lose a bit of the flavour." But really, distilleries want you to drink whiskey the way you want to drink it. So I've yet to meet a distiller who [advises against](#) adding water into a whiskey. In fact, I know a distiller who will say, with every whiskey, you should add two little [drops](#) of water because it'll wake up all those flavours that can't get out. Water is what you need as the catalyst to release all of those flavours. There are countries where [the done thing](#) is to have a whiskey on ice, and you should absolutely drink it over ice if you want to. Put it in a cocktail: whiskey, apple juice, [cranberry](#) juice, a little [slice](#) of lime; beautiful little cocktail. I wouldn't even call it a cocktail, it's a whiskey [tall drink](#) that you could make in your kitchen at home, you know.

THE ANGELS' SHARE

Of course, whiskey is also [steeped in](#) Irish folk[lore](#) and legend. Calley [shares](#) one anecdote from Irish whiskey [lore](#) that reveals how faith once [filled the gaps](#) in scientific understanding. **John Calley:** There's a funny anecdote in old Irish history. So in those [casks](#) that we mature, there's a natural evaporation every year of 2 per cent because the wood is porous. So it comes out through the wood, and if you ever go into a warehouse where all these [casks](#) are [ageing](#), you can just smell it in the air. We call that the 'angels' [share](#)', because in the early days, they didn't know there was an evaporation happening. They [cracked open](#) the [lids](#) and a lot of the whiskey was missing. They would have filled it right up to the very top and they'd come back and after two years, there's like lots of it missing. And because we were quite a religious nation here for a long, long time, the distillers back then just decided that the only explanation is the angels came down from heaven and

took that whiskey for themselves. And that became called the ‘angels’ [share](#).
www.whiskeyisland.ie

Glossary

- **warming up** = riscaldarsi
- **share** = parte, quota
- **to an extent** = in un certo senso
- **brands** = marche
- **tall drink** = long drink
- **filled the gaps** = colmare le lacune
- **ageing** = invecchiare
- **lids** = coperchi
- **affordability** = prezzo accessibile
- **spirit** = distillato
- **pushed out** = espellere
- **breweries** = birrerie
- **costly** = caro
- **former** = precedente
- **sips** = sorsi
- **raise an eyebrow** = mostrare disapprovazione
- **dealt a major blow** = assestare un colpo
- **tastings** = degustazioni
- **hesitated** = esitare
- **sailors** = marinai
- **spelled** = scrivere
- **flooding** = invadere
- **stool** = sgabello
- **knock it back** = bere tutto d'un fiato
- **casks** = botti
- **cracked open** = aprire
- **barley** = orzo
- **Low Countries** = Paesi Bassi
- **hanging in there** = resistere, sopravvivere
- **merged** = fondersi
- **bolder** = più deciso
- **the done thing** = la cosa abituale
- **slice** = fetta
- **lore** = leggenda
- **blended** = mescolare
- **smoother** = più morbido, più delicato
- **family-run business** = azienda a conduzione familiare
- **made its way into** = farsi strada verso
- **trade wars** = guerre commerciali
- **discourage** = sconsigliare

- **in one** = d'un colpo
- **cranberry** = mirtillo rosso
- **reluctance** = riluttanza
- **seized the opportunity** = cogliere l'opportunità
- **ruled the world** = dominare il mondo
- **supplies** = scorte, provviste
- **despite** = nonostante
- **drop** = goccio
- **advises against** = sconsigliare
- **steeped in** = impregnato di
- **insight** = approfondimento
- **navy** = marina
- **traces back to** = risalire a
- **set their product apart** = distinguere